> he did no more than present a ceremonial scarf, as was done by the others, including the British Representative. But the Chinese have the ear of the world, and can later refer to their Press records and present an account of historical events that is wholly untrue. Tibet has no newspapers, either in English or Tibetan, and has therefore no means of exposing these falsehoods.[88]

The fourteenth Dalai Lama was still an infant when World War II broke out and could not possibly have been aware of the changes it was going to bring to the region. Tibet's delicate status as a de facto independent buffer state between India and China was being challenged. For the first time in history, an alliance between China and British India was forged as they fought together against a common enemy—Japan. The Imperial Japanese Army had seized large tracts of territory in eastern China and, later, in December 1941, the British colony of Hong Kong was occupied as well.

Tens of thousands of Chinese troops retreated from China's inland through northern Myanmar into northeastern India. Many were cantoned at Ramgarh in Bihar, now in the state of Jharkhand. Britain and the United States were firmly behind Chiang Kai-shek's forces, and preparations were underway for them to be equipped and sent back to China to fight the Japanese. Sending supplies into China was another major task, as the Japanese had severed traditional routes through Myanmar and other neighbours.

Chiang Kai-shek and his allies saw the need to develop alternative supply routes, and those would have to be from India. After discussions between the Chiang's government and the British ambassador in the wartime Chinese capital of Chongqing, Chiang issued orders in February 1941 to build a new highway from Sichuan, where Chongqing is located, through the trading town of Rima in south eastern Tibet and on to Walong on the Indian side. From there, the road would continue to Assam, where high airfields were being constructed to support the war effort. The British ambassador, Horace James Seymour, supported Chiang's plan and recommended that 'in this matter we should not allow outmoded political conceptions to stand in the way of progress'.[89] Or Britain should not let its pledges to uphold Tibet's internal autonomy interfere with this strategically important highway project.

But the British Government of India opposed the plan because it would not substantially help the war effort and, besides, Tibet's position as a de facto independent buffer state with close ties to Britain and India would be